

THE NAPA DAILY REGISTER, NAPA, CALIF.

SATURDAY, JANUARY 7, 1928.

Historical Sketch of Centenary Methodist Episcopal Church

(Written by Ruth D. Norton and Printed by the Standard Printing Co. through the courtesy of A. H. Smith.)

In any paper of this sort there must of course be the limitations imposed because of lack of complete records. Without the help of Mrs. Penelope Howell and Mrs. E. H. King, there could have been no accuracy in the material presented. To them we are grateful—it is indeed wonderful to have had the opportunity to chat with women who have had such continuous and long loyalty to the church. And in truth the seeker after facts for a paper of this sort is inclined to agree with Dr. J. H. N. Williams in his letter to Dr. McArthur at the time of the celebration in 1925 in which he said, "Your church has a noble history in its noble men and women, and I am sure that you have those about you who are worthy successors of those who laid the foundations well and built carefully thereon." The history of this church is a story of noble and God-fearing men and women who dared to be pioneers and trail blazers, that they might show others the way. And it is the story of these men and women—laymen and pastors and pastor's wives who worked together to make a beginning with twelve members in 1852 develop into a church seventy-five years later with 538 members—that we wish to tell. Each pastor has contributed something—each layman has added his bit—so the church has grown as the result of the entire effort.

The earliest records tell us that in 1851 S. D. Simonds was appointed to the Napa Circuit. This circuit embraced all of Napa Valley and Suisun—and inasmuch as Dr. Simonds had no machine we are inclined to believe that he must have lived a strenuous life! The first class, doubtless organized under his supervision, had as members Mr. and Mrs. David Squibb, Mrs. Electa Burnett Hartson, Mrs. Elizabeth Horrell and Mrs. Maria L. Stillwagon. It is supposed that this class met and held meetings in the old court house when Dr. Simonds came to Napa in making the rounds of his circuit. Dr. Simonds got such good training here, apparently, that he also became the minister at the old First Church in San Francisco, then later went to General Conference and became Editor of the California Christian Advocate.

J. Prier in 1852 and E. A. Hazen in 1853 also served the Napa circuit of which Napa city was a part. During Mr. Hazen's pastorate a parsonage was built on a lot given the Methodists by Mr. Nathan Coombs—the father of Assemblyman Frank L. Coombs. We can assume by this that Mr. Hazen made Napa his headquarters and came here to rest when worn with the labors of "making the circuit."

In 1855 James Corwin was appointed to the Napa circuit with J. J. Cleveland as his assistant. Again in 1856 Corwin was appointed, this time with Colin Anderson as his assistant. In this year Mr. Joseph Howell and his wife, Penelope came to Napa. Mrs. Howell is our only living member of the early church. She will celebrate her hundredth birthday in September of this year. "It is good to live if you live right" she said in talking of the early days of the church and its subsequent growth. With this simple and inclusive philosophy she has managed to nearly reach the century mark.

The story is told that Rev. Corwin saved the boards on his own sawmill and after hauling the boards to town built the church. "It was in this year that 'Jiminy' Corwin built the Church," said Mrs. Howell, "it was just one room, straight up and down boards with hard benches to sit on. But we went to be fed with the word of the Lord, so it did not matter how we had to sit, and the one room was big enough for the twelve members of that church." And such apparently was the spirit of all the founders: David and Fanny Squibb, Elizabeth Horrell, Mr. and Mrs. J. E. Ford, Mr. and Mrs. Victor, Mrs. Thompson, Mrs. Electa Hartson, Joseph and Penelope Howell, and Mrs. Maria L. Stillwagon. They all were there for the dedication of the church in 1858 by Dr. M. C. Briggs, and remained to leave lasting im-

prints of their personalities upon the church.

Dr. W. W. Morrow was the first minister to be appointed to the Napa charge. With the establishment of the church here, Napa was made a separate station. In Dr. Morrow's year here the Sunday School was established with the pastor as superintendent and Mrs. Judge Horrell as assistant. They called at the homes, and brought in twenty-five children to the school.

Rev. W. B. May came to Napa in 1859. A new parsonage was built this year as the other one had become inadequate. This parsonage was built near the church on 4th and Randolph Sts. J. E. Pond took over the superintendency of the Sunday School and maintained it for many years. Under his guidance the school became an influence not only in the church but in the community.

During the pastorate of Nelson Reesoner (1860-1862) the Napa Collegiate Institute was established here as a private enterprise by a Mr. Hamm. In 1861 W. S. Turner purchased the school and ran it for several years. Mr. and Mrs. Joseph F. Lamdin came to the church during the ministry of P. L. Haynes (1862-1864). Miss Gertrude Lamdin, our gifted organist is their youngest child and only daughter.

In 1864 W. J. Maclay, an uncle of Miss Janet Maclay, was appointed to the Napa church. A few days after his arrival in Napa the parsonage was destroyed by fire. All the records of the church and all his own personal belongings were destroyed. The story is told that the fire was started by a neighbor boy, who, wishing to punish the family cow, set fire to the barn. The reason for his desire to get revenge is not known. The fire destroyed not only the barn, but the parsonage as well. It is not known whether anyone, other than the cow and the minister, was punished.

As a result of this fire a new parsonage had to be built. Probably the membership had grown to make more than a one-room church necessary, and a new church was also erected during the years that Mr. Maclay served this charge. The total valuation of the two buildings was \$15,000. The old church was moved away and sold to the colored people. The new church was dedicated in August 1867.

D. A. Dryden was the pastor of the Napa church in 1867. In 1868, when J. L. Trefren was minister, F. A. Sawyer and his wife, Martha, came to the church from New Hampshire. During this year Mr. Turner sold the Napa Collegiate Institute to a Mr. Smith. Mr. Smith ran it for a year and then sold it to a group of Napa citizens—Chancellor Hartson, C. Fellows, Nathan Coombs, A. W. Norton, G. Linn, and H. Fowler. These gentlemen improved the grounds and buildings of the institute and carried on its work. In 1870 Mr. and Mrs. B. F. Sawyer came to Napa.

Wesley Dennett, who came in 1870, was the next minister here. Wesley Dennett was one of the pioneers in Methodism in California. His sons, Senator L. L. Dennett of Modesto, and Dr. E. P. Dennett, now editor of the California Christian Advocate, have carried on in a splendid fashion. During his time the Napa Collegiate Institute was purchased by the Methodist Episcopal church. Professor T. C. George was the first president of the college under the new rule.

Dr. T. S. Dunn in 1872 carried on the work of the men who had gone before him. He was known as a forceful preacher and worker. Chauncy S. Dunn, one of the leading lawyers in Sacramento, and active member of the First Methodist Church there, recently deceased, was his son.

Rev. Stephen Bowers came to Napa in 1873. In 1874 W. R. Gohar came to be the minister here, and during that year Mr. and Mrs. John P. Corlett and family, Mr. and Mrs. S. M. Tool, and S. E. Holden came to Napa. Mr. Tool came to be associated for a few years with the Napa Register. Mr. Holden came to the Sawyer Tanning Co., and Mr. Corlett and his sons established the planing mill. All of these people served faithfully and well in the church. In 1876 Anna Smyth came to the N. C. I. to teach. She and Mr. Holden were married in 1879. Mrs. Holden was one of the leaders amongst the women in the church. Mrs. Holden was a woman of great charm; she and her husband held their spacious home ever open to the call of the church.

In 1874 Prof. L. L. Rodgers came to the N. C. I. as president. Two new buildings were erected during the year. The first class was graduated in 1874. Prof. W. C. Damon, who came to teach in the college, took over the Sunday school superintendency and had it for sixteen years. In the early 70's A. W. Norton, long a resident of Napa, came into the church.

E. S. Todd came to preach here in 1877. Between that time and 1880 Chancellor Hartson, and L. J. Norton came to the church. Prof. A. E. Lasher of New York came to be college president and appointed a faculty of nine members. The grounds were laid out and improved.

Rev. and Mrs. E. H. King came to Napa with their family during the time that A. J. Wells was a minister here (1880-1881). Percy, the oldest son—now our Superior Judge—had come to school here that year and they came to be with him. They and their family have remained to be an influence, not only in Napa county but in the state of California. Mrs. Hartson took charge of the Primary department in this year, and kept it until she was teaching children's children. In 1880 Joseph Lamdin, the first Napa layman to be so honored, was sent to General Conference at Cincinnati.

John Coyle spent seven years as pastor of the Napa church. He came first in 1882 and stayed two years. At this time I. G. Herron and his family came to Napa. Prof. C. B. Ridgeway came to Napa College as instructor in mathematics and vice-president. Dr. Coyle's second pastorate began in 1887 and lasted until 1892. During Dr. Coyle's second time here Mrs. S. E. Holden started her young women's S. S. class which she kept for many years.

Between Dr. Coyle's pastorates, for three years, Dr. M. C. Briggs served the church. Many interesting stories are told of Dr. Briggs, who was known as a fiery orator. He proved that the people like it, because it was at this time that the church was crowded beyond its capacity, so that chairs had to be put in the aisles to accommodate the overflow. He preached powerful sermons, among other things on temperance, and the importance of worshiping on Sunday. He was, it is said, one of the most punctual men in the world. He was determined that all church meetings should start on time. He often came into the pulpit on the dot of the hour holding his watch in his hand. He would come into the Sunday School with watch in hand, and if Prof. Damon the Superintendent were one minute late would start the service. He loved getting ahead of Prof. Damon, as the professor was a prompt man himself and not often late. One fears that perhaps Dr. Briggs might have a fidget or two now.

Chancellor Hartson was the second man to go to General Conference from Napa when he attended the New York Conference in 1888. In 1887 Dr. James N. Beard came to be the president of the college. He later went to the Deaconess Training School in San Francisco. Prof. Chas. W. Treat came to Napa in 1888 to teach in the college. He was an active worker in the Epworth League and Sunday School, and conducted a teachers' training class which attracted Sunday School teachers of all denominations.

Dr. Doremus A. Hayes, one of our most brilliant preachers, came to Napa in 1892 as a young man. After serving three years, he went to the Iliff School of Theology at Denver for one year, and from there to the Garrett Biblical Institute at Evanston, Illinois, where he has been ever since. About this he wrote to Dr. McArthur at the time of the eighth anniversary of the dedication of the new church: "Thirty years ago, and more, we spent three very happy years in the Napa pastorate. I learned so much there about what young preachers ought to know that I have been teaching preachers ever since upon the basis of that experience. I hope you are training your pastors as well now as in the last century."

Dr. Hayes has a quiet, but effective, sense of humor which is well brought out in this story told us by Mrs. King. During Dr. Hayes' pastorate the teacher of music at the college led the singing in the choir. The music at this time was very famous. For three consecutive Sunday mornings the choir had sung the same anthem. When Dr. Hayes came to read the scripture lesson for the day he read the lines "Oh sing unto the Lord a new song." Needless

(Continued on Page Three.)

Administrator's Report

by California—

spectfully makes this return of all estates of decedents that have come into his hands for six months

Date of Death	Money Due to Decedent	Money Due by Decedent	Balance of Money with Co. Treasurer	Property exclusive of Money in hands of Administrator	Remarks
None	None	None	None	None	Quiet title matter
None	\$ 170.87	\$ 87.89	\$ 989.07	None	Final proceedings
3438.45	3438.45	3438.45	2801.86	Real & Pers. Prop.	Property deferred
553.04	553.04	553.04	None	None	Pending final settlement
212.10	212.10	212.10	32.78	None	Closed
104.99	104.99	104.99	None	None	Closed
2013.09	1371.99	641.10	None	None	Pending final settlement
263.91	263.91	263.91	None	None	Closed
460.59	460.59	460.59	None	None	Closed
115.80	115.80	115.80	403.80	None	Pending final settlement
1386.94	1386.94	1386.94	None	None	Closed
98.70	98.70	98.70	None	None	Closed under section 1726a C. C. P.
321.99	321.99	321.99	96.99	Real & Pers. Prop.	Appraisement
402.46	402.46	402.46	347.46	None	Pending final settlement
67.46	67.46	67.46	40.80	None	—
100.00	100.00	100.00	25.00	Pers. Prop.	—
1021.09	1021.09	1021.09	None	None	Special Administration pending final settlement
None	None	None	None	Unknown	Pending final settlement
None	None	None	294.83	None	—
None	None	None	None	None	Quiet title matter
None	None	None	105.75	Real & Pers. Prop.	—
None	None	None	None	None	—
None	None	None	15.62	None	Less than \$100
None	None	None	None	None	Under Section 1726a C. C. P.
12.90	12.90	12.90	12.90	None	Less than \$100
89.04	89.04	89.04	29.04	None	Under Section 1726a C. C. P.
47.60	47.60	47.60	47.60	None	Less than \$100
None	None	None	None	None	Under Section 1726a C. C. P.
6.55	6.55	6.55	6.55	None	Less than \$100
None	None	None	None	None	Under Section 1726a C. C. P.

says that he is the Coroner and Ex-officio Public Administrator of Napa County and that the foregoing come into his hands for six months ending December 31st, 1927.

Expenditures of any kind made on account of any of said estates. Nor is he associated in business with any of them.

before me this 3rd day of January, 1928.

THEODORE J. TREADWAY,

Public Administrator.

HENRY C. OSBORN,

Attorney for Public Administrator.

County of Napa, State of California.